

PICOCON 43



Wyrmhole Anthology

Credit to Katherine Chahbani for this wonderful cover art

FOREWORD

Last year, Cliff convinced me to be the Editor and to help out in the creation of last year's Wyrmtongue. I have not been quite so enthusiastic as he was in advertising for this anthology and would like to thank everyone who has nonetheless submitted to it. I am continuing the tradition of printing this anthology far later than it should have been, but hopefully not too late. If any errors are found, they are likely my fault.

This edition of the anthology begins with *New World* by Ruth Raqeeef. It goes into the far future, describing the encounter humans have with an unexpected alien civilisation on a planet called Helios. Next, we have an entry by our current chair of vice, Michael Porat-Bachmutsky, *Tannin*, told from the perspective of an old mage that talks about his relationship with a venerable dragon. This is followed by *Rust Wyrms*, by Katherine Chahbani, our future tech-priestess and who also did the art for this anthology's cover. The titular Rust Wyrms is the name of an old spaceship on its last legs, carrying freight across the stars.

After this is Juairiyah Raqib's *Close Encounters of the Wyrms Kind* a surreal story with some time travelling shenanigans, resulting from an unfortunate encounter of wyrms, with some definite inspiration from a certain webcomic. The last piece of prose is *The Worm Will Wait* by Julien C H Cheung. This follows the perspective of Grace, one of four members of an alien expedition that one can't help but be nervous about.

At the end of this anthology, we have two pieces of poetry. *Through the Center of the Earth* and *Jörmungandr*, by Michael Porat-Bachmutsky and Alyssa Renata respectively. Many thanks to Alyssa, our current techpriest, for helping out with printing the night before Picocon. I won't describe these poems except to say that I very much enjoyed them and hope you do too.

I'd like to once again thank everyone who submitted an entry to the Wyrmtongue anthology, and I hope some of you reading will consider submitting entries to future editions.

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— Kai Lam

The Editor

March 2025

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New World

by Ruth Raqeef

I

It was early morning on the planet X-765884 (nicknamed Helio by the crew) when the New Hope entered its upper atmosphere. The sleek warship's destination was the western coastline of the planet's largest continent. The repurposed cruiser was shaped like the starfish once inhabiting Earth's oceans, which had long since dried up. Nobody had set foot on Earth in centuries; its surface a toxic chemical soup brewed by the industrial giants who now belonged to ages past. The New Hope had been sent by the Human Alliance government, now stationed on Mars, with its crew handpicked specially for this once-in-a-lifetime mission. There were only twenty of them on board and their captain was a short, stocky man named Adam.

"Alright! Listen up!" Adam called out as the ship's thrusters slowly manoeuvred them to about 10 km above sea level, before deploying the solar sail that doubled as a massive parachute. The ship's crew were huddled around the table in the control room, nursing mugs of hot coffee as their eyes drooped with exhaustion.

"We're the first to ever make contact with an alien civilisation, so I need everyone on their best behaviour... got it?"

"We don't know anything about them," pointed out Jamie Jamie, one of the mechanics. "What if they're hostile?" "That's what I'm here for, isn't it?" Sarah smirked, leaning back in her seat, a calloused hand patting the machine gun she always had strapped to her chest. She was one for old school weapons.

"It's unlikely that they are hostile," Adam said. "This planet showed us none of the indicators of nuclear war, or war of any kind, in our scans, which is precisely why this mission was cleared in the first place. Ain't that right, Doc?"

Dr Ramos nodded curtly, leaning back in his seat. "Exactly. It was a stroke of luck that the first life-bearing planet we discovered seems to be inhabited by peaceful and intelligent lifeforms. I suspect we will learn a lot from them."

Once the ship was a few hundred metres from the ground, Adam gave it the final landing order.

“New Hope, extend and make contact.”

The ship responded in its usual low, monotone voice. “Of course, Captain Falkner.”

Out of the five sprawling arms of the ship extended five broad, metallic legs, which planted themselves firmly in the grassy meadow that overlooked a stretch of golden sand and the dark sea beyond.

“Could be a nice holiday destination, this,” Adam muttered to himself. “It’s like those old pictures of Earth...”

“Captain Falkner, I have detected a foreign presence,” the ship’s computer said.

“Jesus!” Jamie cried.

“Shut up.” Ramos shot her a loathsome glare. “The residents must be coming to greet us. New Hope, how far away are they?” “They will be here in approximately ten minutes. They appear to be travelling in a land vehicle.”

“It must be the nearby inhabitants,” Ramos mused. “This will be a good opportunity to observe them in their natural state.”

“Careful, Doc, you’re talking about them like they’re animals,” Adam pointed out.

“I am merely curious about the new species we are about to meet. You don’t understand how momentous this occasion is. We will be the first to look upon those who are truly other.”

In just under ten minutes, the ship’s external cameras showed the crew a large, circular, silver pod racing through the long grasses, halting cleanly a few paces away from one of the New Hope’s legs.

“Looks like the welcome party’s here,” Adam drawled. “Let’s go out and meet them.”

Everyone filed down the ship’s ramp as its steel mouth opened wide to let them out. Adam was at the head of the line, followed closely by Ramos.

“I think it’s best if I speak to them first,” Ramos whispered to Adam.

“Be my guest, Doc. You’re the expert.”

Ramos watched with barely hidden glee as the pod’s sides slid open, his breath caught in his throat at the prospect of being the first to greet the new lifeforms. What would they look like? Would they be like the fantastical creatures dreamt up by the minds of the men of Earth in ages past?

The creatures emerged from the pod and walked up to Ramos. They stood in front of

him and waited for him to speak.

“No. No. No.” Ramos was shaking his head and pulling at his face with his hands. “It cannot be.”

One of the creatures made an unintelligible noise, pointing at Ramos and then itself, chattering excitedly with its companions in a language that had been extinct on Earth for hundreds of thousands of years.

“No!” Ramos screamed, the rest of the crew too shocked to utter a single word. They all gazed at the creatures before them, familiar yet unfamiliar at the same time. A species torn apart before the dawn of civilisation, reunited at long last.

Ramos sank to his knees, covering his face in the grass. A kind hand grasped his chin, urging him to look up into their eyes. “You are human,” Ramos murmured, gazing up at the face of another man.

The morning sun cast its bright rays upon them as the old world met the new.

II

Life on Helios, or Hura as the inhabitants called it, was interesting, Ramos had to admit. His initial shock at finding humans on this far-flung planet had been broken down gradually by the patience of his new host. The crew of the New Hope had already set off for Mars, but not before sending a detailed message to their immediate superiors at Human Alliance HQ. Ramos was the only one who had decided to stay, determined not to miss out on this opportunity to study a convergent culture of humanity.

“And... when... did you... come?” Ramos could speak broken fragments of their language now, a language wiped from Earth’s memory. His host smiled and pointed at the walls of the cave he had taken Ramos into. “Look.”

The walls were full of detailed depictions of the night sky, carefully traced with a dark red paint. Ramos could see a large circle in the centre - much, much larger than the stars dotted around it.

“Earth,” Exi, his host, said. “It was very, very long ago. It is said that we left more than 300,000 years ago.”

Ramos shook his head in wonder. This civilisation was in its heyday at a time when other human species still existed, when mammoths and sabre toothed tigers roamed

the Earth. He looked at Exi, whose gaze was fixed on the paintings, eyes filled with a soft reverence. Ramos's mind wandered to a thought that was growing familiar to him: why were Exi and his people so gentle, so different to the humans of Earth and Mars in their philosophy, but so familiar in terms of appearance?

"You want to know more?" asked Exi, smiling at the man he had come to regard as a friend.

"Please." Ramos sat on the ground, facing Exi.

"I will tell you our origin story. This has been passed on for generations since the very beginning and is no less important than it was then. The founder of our civilisation on Earth was the woman they called Hur. She hailed from the Heat Region, where humans first emerged from, but travelled all across the world, braving the cold lands of the north and south. People flocked to Hur, enthralled by her courage and spirit, and began to worship her in a fashion. She will always be known as the first leader of our people, the Hurans. The first empire rose up under her control."

"The first empire?" Ramos repeated.

"Then there was the second, the third, the fourth, and then eventually the fifth. This world is the home of the Fifth Empire of Hur. We were a species full of turmoil back then and that is why our empires rose and fell. Only the fifth survived and it will endure until the end of time."

"Why did you- I mean, the Hurans, leave Earth?"

"The Hurans on Earth had reached the peak of technological advance. They had explored every nook and cranny of their planet. What was there left to do? When they tried to reach out to their fellow human species, they were attacked and forced to use violence beyond the thought of those poor creatures to defend themselves."

Ramos shivered at the thought of one of his own ancestors facing down one of Exi's, a gaping chasm between their minds that had only just been bridged.

Exi continued, "The stars have always been special to us. We knew of other planets out there and we knew of this one, a planet with the ability to sustain life. Over the course of one century, the Fifth Huran Empire relocated and that was the last we saw of Earth. I have seen old pictures, of course, but what is it like now?"

Ramos closed his eyes. "I have never seen it. It became uninhabitable 800 years ago. What remains of humanity resides on Mars."

Exi's face was frozen in a smile. "I do not understand." "Uninhabitable. The surface, the atmosphere is toxic," Ramos tried to explain, acutely aware of the language barrier. But he suspected that was not what Exi was questioning.

"We must leave." Exi stood up abruptly and motioned for Ramos to follow him.

"Why?"

"It is dangerous."

"Dangerous?"

"The others must not find out."

"Stand down, Exi." A tall woman, whose face seemed to be sculpted out of marble, blocked their path. "Give him to us."

"No, Hur. He has done nothing wrong." Exi's tone was unaltered on the surface, but Ramos could sense the undercurrents of worry that ran through his friend's voice.

"Did you not hear what he said? His ancestors destroyed the mother world."

Ramos could only make out a couple of words, her accent being slightly different to Exi's, but his stomach churned as her cold eyes alighted upon him and his hands trembled uncontrollably by his sides.

"His blood will be the first to be spilled on Hura."

III

There were no Hurans present to observe Ramos' impending death. He was left alone with his thoughts, a thin needle still embedded in the back of his neck. They had injected him with a clear liquid a few hours ago and Exi had assured him that it would be a painless death. His host had been the last to bid him farewell, the only one to show him any kindness in this cruelly gentle world.

"Do not be angry with them, Ramos," were Exi's last words. "They do not know what they are doing. This is the only way they can mourn the old world."

The old world, Ramos thought bitterly, while fat drops of sweat rolled down his forehead into his eyes, the old world he had never seen. He, like everyone on Mars, had been born on the dusty, red planet. Earth was nothing but a distant memory, a memory of the atrocities mankind had once committed. Perhaps the Hurans were right to punish him for the sins of his ancestors. Ramos didn't belong to Helios - Hura: he was a stranger

to the Hurans and their way of life. The Human Alliance had its rivals on Mars and Ramos had served in its military as a young man, sent into the harsh deserts and plains of the Martian landscape to fight a war that had been started long before his birth. And then there was Exi, sweet, kind, Exi, who had never thought an unkind thought in his life. Even the Hurans who had condemned Ramos to death did not do it out of anger or malice, but as a natural progression of their idea of justice. He understood that much at least, but he was from a different branch of humanity than them, and could not remove the hatred he felt for them in his heart.

“Ramos?”

Ramos could not lift his head up, locked into a kneeling position by a steel chain bound round his neck, attached to the ceiling in an imitation of that long-lost method of execution.

“Exi...”

“You are still alive.”

“Should I not be?”

Exi frowned. “This process is quite outdated. It derives from the methods of the third Huran Empire. We have no other way, however, of taking a life.”

Ramos snorted. “You could have stabbed me. You could have shot me. You could have strangled me.”

“You speak in your own language and I cannot understand you.” “There are no words in your language for what I speak of. Exi! I cannot stand this waiting. Take the sharpest object you can find and ram it through my skull.”

“Do not make such requests of me, Ramos.” If Ramos could have seen Exi’s face, he would have been surprised at the sheer anguish etched in its usually placid features. The Huran’s shadow was cast above Ramos’ head and the latter wished he could look at his friend one last time.

“Then save me.”

“I wish I could. There is no way to reverse the effects of the chemical.”

“Then tell me why. Why do you Hurans care so much about the old world? You, who left it in the days of human infancy? Tell me why you are so docile, so devoid of the human spirit!” Ramos was almost screaming, his despair echoing off the cool, steel walls that surrounded them.

“The human spirit?”

“The spirit of conquering! The longing to expand! The desire to make others submit!”

“Impossible.”

“Impossible?” Ramos was flummoxed.

“Of course. The fourth Huran Empire collapsed due to much internal strife and those who rose from its ashes, the first Empress of the Fifth Huran Empire and her advisors, took the only possible course of action.”

Ramos’ breath caught in his throat. He could see, with terrifying clarity, what Exi was going to say next. His heartbeat slowed as a chill spread down his spine.

“Genetic modification of the brain. A simple deletion of that ‘human spirit’ you mentioned. For the good of all Hurans and the creatures around us-”

“Those ‘creatures’ were my ancestors. And they were much more human than you.”

“Perhaps. I have never claimed to be ‘human’, although you define me as such.”

Ramos screwed up his eyes, willing himself not to cry in front of someone so alien, someone who wouldn’t understand why he was crying.

“Goodbye, Ramos,” Exi whispered. “I am sorry.”

“For what?” Memories of Exi’s kindness rushed through Ramos’ mind, the feel of Exi’s cool touch upon his skin a balm to what was to come.

“For not being human.”

Ramos closed his eyes for the very last time as Exi stroked his hair with a strong, inhuman hand. **ΨΦ**

Tannin

by Michael Porat-Bachmutsky

I had sat on the peak of Mount Tannin'un since the last day's eve. Sleep eluded me that night; my wait for Tannin was worth the heavy bags under my eyes. I would have sat there for days should the need have been present. Tannin was never concerned by the worries of man, even less so than most other dragons. He may have cared for me, but it might not have been true caring - rather a form of mutual respect. At the very least, I hope he respected me. To tell the truth, neither my martial prowess nor my skill at magecraft could have truly rivalled his. Perhaps he saw the way I wielded them both in tandem and understood the rare intuition it requires, or perhaps he recognised the advance of mankind into dragon's territory. It has been quite too long for me to really remember what I thought then. Naturally, I do now know the true reasoning for his keeping me close.

Either way, he called me to the mountain, and I dared not be late. One does not make a dragon wait without expecting harsh consequences. I suspect I would have waited days for him, watching the fog wash over the forests, rivers, and rolling hills far beneath me, like the tide washing over a sandy shoreline, giving slight glimpses of what lay below every so often. Now that I say it, I realise the comparison is quite fitting, since I saw some sar'tan - you might know them as giant crabs - moving amongst the trees! Where was I? Oh, yes. Luckily, I hadn't needed to wait so long. Tannin arrived a day before he told me to arrive! At the break of dawn I saw him coming. The humongous serpentine figure rising out of the fog, jagged celestine horns and ridges encrusted with glowing amethyst blades. And rows of talons, sharper than any fishmonger's knife and harder than any diamond! Pale blue hair erupted from between his horns, flowing waves crashing violently against the wind. I must imagine, had that been my first encounter with a dragon I might have fainted on the spot. Not even from the sight of the creature (though that would not have done much good either), but just from the fear of not seeing any form of crevice, ravine, or cave from which such a colossal creature could have emerged. Back then I did not know where you dragons hid. I believed, like a few others, that they hid deep underground and would only leave through winding tunnels carved solely for their benefit, maze-like in a way humanity could not comprehend.

There were some who thought the ground bent to your will to dive through the earth like a worm, and remould the surface in such a way no cracks were left perceptible. They weren't far off, I suppose.

Even being accustomed to the fact it still amazes me. I wish I had savoured the mystery longer. Anyway, you should have seen him! He was utterly and purely majestic. He still is somewhat, although bones cannot compare to the pearlescent scales. You can see that he was far larger than the two of you combined! A true beast if there ever was one. To witness him emerging from the fog was incomparable. Of course, he did not see me sitting on the mountaintop immediately, so he coiled up around the mountain below me. As soon as he began wrapping around I started hiking down from my seat, eventually coming face to face with him.

"Tannin. I apologise for making you wait." I told him.

Tannin knew the language of humans yet often despised the act of speaking it. He gave me a simple nod and look, which I appreciated as him acknowledging his own earliness.

"Mind my asking, why did you call me out here?" I tried to speak concisely and with purpose.

He simply unfurled his lips and growled in response, which I assumed to be a warning not to ask, or that I would be told later. I went on, asking about his health and the dealings in the west. The Sorlarchans, the people that lived in the west, had called for war against the dragons a year prior to our reunion. I believe that now they have managed to drag in the rest of the Northern continent on this warpath. He answered as I expected him to, news much unchanged from the last time I saw him. A decade in dragon's time is not more than an instant.

Eventually, our brief conversation was interrupted by him bowing his head to me. Mind you, this was not an action I had ever encountered from him before. I didn't immediately understand that it was an invitation to mount him, though it didn't take me long either, for dragons do not wait long. I had never ridden a dragon before, and I suspect nearly no man has. 'Tis an odd thing, to ride a dragon - to sit upon the scales of which we would normally watch in such awe from below; grabbing tightly onto the body of

the beast, half serpent, half bird, hoping not to fall off, not from fear of death but from wanting the flight to last.

On Tannin's back everything seemed so clear. The sky was above the clouds, the clouds above the mountains, and the mountains above the trees. We leapt up higher and higher, out of daylight and into the breathless night. As if the blue were only a blanket, and the true depth and limit of the sky reached far further beyond. What shocked me was when Tannin dove back down towards the land, moving faster and faster until we reached impossible speeds. What's more, when we approached the ground, it opened up to swallow us whole! We swam through the expanse, the weight beneath my feet shifting as we did so. Slowly, we emerged from the other side to a place I immediately knew was far more vast than where I had come from. Behind us, the hole closed, and all that lay ahead of us was this place - what you call home.

Alright then. I'm going to head back to sleep. I'm tired of storytelling now.

You want to know more? Will you not let an old man rest a while longer?

Very well, I'll indulge you this once.

After we came to this place, the 'Wyrmhole', as I now call it, Tannin flew me through. It was rather strange to me at first, the floating islands drifting through the air like fish in the sea. Behind them, the purple void stretched endlessly, interspersed with glowing stars that were too far to cast clear shadows, yet close enough to touch. Existence back in my world does not proceed that way; we are far simpler. You wouldn't quite understand. This place is all you know. Although, perhaps this place is simple, and humanity has complicated things far too much. No matter, it depends only on the observer. Tannin, the hulking thing, brought me after some time to this island.

"I have lived too long. Use your sword. Slay me." He spoke to me after I dismounted.

I was at a loss. I had only ever heard him speak the human tongue when necessary, and even then he would never speak so candidly without riddle or embedded meaning.

"Slay me. I must die by your hand." He spoke again. The serpent's body turned its side to me, pointed its head away from me. "Between the scales. Thrust your sword."

I don't remember much of what happened then, I'll be honest. Tears were jagged in my eyes, burning my skin as they rolled down my cheeks. He begged me, more and more he pleaded with me, and I stopped refusing when I realised he would never stop asking - when he told me he couldn't die if I didn't kill him. You dragons, you don't die, do you? You just age, and age, and age. Your mind outgrowing your body and your body outgrowing your health. At some point, your lives become suffering and you have no way of stopping it, for not even destined death can save you.

I killed Tannin. With this blade, imbued with ancient draconic arcana, found on the peak of the oldest mountain of the oldest country, I stabbed between the scales. And he shut his eyes smiling, while I shut mine crying. The scales, the muscles, all of him faded then and there. He disintegrated into paper-thin leaves of iridescence. All that remains here are his bones, weathered yet never aging.

Now. I have indulged you long enough. I know you dragons do not like waiting, but if you want to hear another story from the oh-so-great dragon slayer, you will wait.

Goodbye. **ΨΦ**

Rust Wyrn

by Katherine Chahbani

Space, the final frontier. Many have dreamed to explore it, see the wonders that hide within the vast cosmos of our universe. It has been millennia since space travel became a reality, no longer a dream, a hope, a blurry image taken by primitive technology from ages long past. Intergalactic travel had become a mundane reality. People going to and from in what could best be described as a tin can hurdling through vast empty swathes at speeds sometimes exceeding light itself. It's hard today to imagine this used to be reserved for the best of the best, elite groups that made money in ways shadier than the dark side of the moon, these were the representatives, ambassadors of our people. It's hard to imagine that simple people like me could one day, simply decide to visit the incomprehensible, mind bending void on the simplest of whims.

I have grown blind to the notion of space travel as something exhilarating. Everyday, I wake up, somewhere new each time, either surrounded by the void or, on rarer occasions, on a planet where cargo finally meets its destination. Neither these places nor the people I meet are constants. They're but a fleeting moment, a small piece of the wider cold universe which cares little for us. What I have learned is that the only constants here, are me and the hunk of junk I lovingly call the 'Rust Wyrn'. A sleek, long, outdated freighter, with an orange-red body from when that was all the rage, adorned with plates of metal and plastic of many colours, never that same orange-red, each telling a story than no one else could ever truly appreciate. It never made much sense to properly repair the hull in a cohesive manner; faster than light (FTL) travel is costly in many ways, especially on the frail exterior of ships, even modern ones. Despite its age, this bucket of bolts was comfortable, to some extent, and it could still travel efficiently and do its job.

The interior, much like me and the hull, has seen better days, time seems to have drained the colours from the furniture and art that tried to mimic a humble apartment. Aside from the living quarters, the main areas were the cockpit, the cargo room and the engine room. The first of which I would consider both the best and worst of areas this ship could offer. It's where all the action happened that became so ro-

manticised. Different media always depict a bustling crew in this room, with people getting ready for combat or liftoff, with lively, chaotic conversations about how their poor ship, unsuitable for battle, could never stand up against an armada. It's quiet, the last war was generations ago, the visuals of explosions - replaced by a slab of black granite in which all life seemingly exists. The wide bay window gives into a captain's, or more aptly, a driver's chair, well worn in, next to a console with faded buttons whose inscriptions became useless with time. Every time I sit there, I get to enjoy the view of something I have seen again and again, combined with the reminder that I get to argue with myself over the fate of this ship as I outrun an army of delivery deadlines with ease.

The cargo and engine rooms are both important and insignificant. Most times, I am only there to make sure the shipments are still here, make sure the engine has yet to give out, or simply for a change of scenery. Recently though, something strange has happened, the colour of these rooms had been fading as well. Even more unusual is that no one has ever complained about it, the load delivered was always accepted, I've yet to hear someone complain that their shipment of furniture or what else was discoloured. I thought this was FTL sickness, a side effect of travelling too fast for too long, but this isn't one of them. Usually it's nausea, with rare cases of hallucinations, especially when travelling alone. Something was happening and I did not know what, but it mattered not. I still had a job to do. People, time, the universe, even I, cared little for what a small piece of the universe felt.

In order to achieve FLT speed for a consistent amount of time, ships make use of worm-holes. Some use naturally available ones, but better equipped ships can create their own. Depending on the destination and the sum of the payout, I make a usage of either. Despite the banal nature of going from one place to another, every single day, these gateways through time and space make it all ever so slightly worth it. Entering a worm-hole is something few still get to experience despite the prevalence of FTL travel, as it's usually short lived for the commute most need to make. To enter such a tunnel is to experience the impossible. Inside, you get to see alternate realities, images of worlds with sometimes only the slightest of variations. In the infinity of the universe, some things simply don't happen, and those moments of travel let you see what could

have been but is too late to change.

This is possibly the last flight I will ever make, I simply cannot go on. Colours no longer drain as even the exterior of the Wyrms, with all its dents and haphazardly repairs, stares at me in monotone black and white, the same one I've grown sick and tired from seeing in a void that neither answers nor stares back. One last jump to end it all, one last jump to put the final nail in the black hole that is this cursed career, one last jump before the 'Rust Wyrms' gets sold as a the piece of scrap it is. And so, I enter the passageway that would lead to the resting place of what I carry this time. Lights of different fantastical colours flood the room, fantastical black, grey, white. As always, I start to hear the creaks and noises of plates being torn off by the journey-. I try and take in the scenery and absorb the mysteries that the multiverse hides. Planets that I've visited, in one world never existed or ceased to be. More plates are violently pulled away. In another reality, some person I met became a wealthy business owner. Red lights shine from the console, replacing the usual light blue glow-. And in yet another one, space travel never left the realm of the imaginary. Alarms start sounding-. In one world, I never traveled as I realized much sooner that the wealth made from this venture, was never worth it. The computer whines and screams about the reactor, the hull, the life support-. Never has one of these images truly captivated me, they were interesting in their own right, but what use did I have for impossibilities that involved those I didn't know. Systems panic from the overwhelming stress-. At least, not until now. The ship was never meant to be in FTL this long-. In some ridiculous twist of fate, the cosmos has given me an answer to a question I never dared to ask the very same moment I answered it. The 'Rusty Wyrms' begs and pleads-. Was success ever worth the loss of self? Am I really more than a small piece the universe can toss away? The large window cracks, the cargo is engulfed in flames, the engine has given up, the cacophony of alarms turns to eerie silence from a simple push of a button that looks brand new-. I stare at this image of me, blinded by how bright and colourful it is. In the final few moments, the cold universe is replaced by the warm embrace of the 'Rust Wyrms'-. $\Psi\Phi$

Close Encounters of the Worm Kind

by Juairiyah Raqib

When I first found the gap in reality, it was entirely by accident. For days after hearing a loud crash in the middle of the night, I'd set up a simple drop trap using a clean bedsheet and waited nightly for any sound until sleep caught me. After seven days, the tell-tale screech of surprise echoed against tile, and I threw off my covers, barrelling down the stairs before my sheets hit the mattress and wrenching the kitchen door wide open. Something was writhing beneath the sheet, but all I could make out was the base of its long armoured back, like a crocodile but with burnished red scales. I should have known better than to approach without caution. It must have smelled or heard my approach, because it released a hiss like a steam engine, stilling, before its powerful tail slammed my breath from my chest and my body into the kitchen cabinets behind me with a deafening crash. To be accurate, it knocked me into last week.

You would be correct to question how I arrived at my conclusion so quickly about where – or rather when – I was when I landed. In my confused state, it took me some seconds to be aware of anything other than the aching of my body, and some more to realise that the strange creature which had attacked me had disappeared. As had the sheet, any sign of entry, and the various cameras which I had set up around the kitchen in preparation. Leaning heavily on the counter with one arm and holding my head with the other, I would have concluded that the entire thing must have been some sort of hallucination, but a too-familiar voice called from the top of the stairs.

“I’ll go check what it is,” I’d loudly informed my housemate a week earlier, who’d been blearily peering out from her bedroom doorway. “I’m sure it’s just a pest or something.”

The me in the kitchen froze, certain that I hadn’t found myself in the kitchen a week ago, and tried to observe an escape from the situation that was about to occur. I couldn’t remain, unless I wanted to risk creating an offshoot timeline and potentially dooming myself (both of us!) to fading out of existence in some manner worse than death. The windows didn’t open wide enough for any three-dimensional person to squeeze through; the back door was right out, as it was locked and the various keys kept in our individual rooms. Besides, it was sticky and would jam every time we tried to open or close it.

The various cupboards and cabinets were either too small or too full, and the small wooden table was both piled with empty takeaway containers and holding two wooden stools beneath it.

I heard myself trundling down the stairs inelegantly, and weakly staggered forward to find somewhere to hide. In doing so, I stepped back into the future, where the creature was once again before me, having finally accepted its situation somewhat and attempting to chew through the fabric covering itself. I half-turned, conflicted between addressing the unearthly creature before me or the impossible portal behind, but finally tiptoed sideways towards the creature's head, preferring the familiar risk of biting that came with any animal that I'd ever handled to another potential attack by its tail.

As a zoology student and animal rescue volunteer, I'd been trained on what to do in emergency rescue situations with feral or wild animals. The first and most ideal course of action was to focus on my own safety, and leave any particularly dangerous animals to the already trained professionals. But in my blind arrogance setting up this primitive trap, I'd already broken that first rule.

Lifting the gnawed remains of what had once been a fitted sheet for my mattress, I regretted my choice and drew back, eyes darting around in case I made any other strange travels. It wasn't just crocodilian: it had a long scaly body, and snapped powerful toothy jaws as I would expect from one, but its feet extended with long talons, and wide elephantine frills erupted from the back of its head as it attempted, not unsuccessfully, to intimidate me.

"It's okay," I told the thing. "I'm not here to hurt you."

Of course, the creature didn't understand me. It lunged forward, and I scrambled back until the wall of cupboards hit my back. The creature briefly paused, to the relief of my screaming nerves, before winding towards me in a serpentine manner despite its clawed feet. But before its pointed teeth could arrive close enough for me to flinch, cry, or defecate in petrification, it disappeared; I was left alone in the kitchen, staring blankly at thin air with only my aching body as proof that what had just transpired

wasn't entirely a figment of my imagination. I reached forward to where the creature had vanished, cautiously prodding the air before me. Perhaps the creature was traveling to a time when nobody had been in the kitchen, for whatever strange reason. We rarely had meat in the house anyway, being a majority plant-based household. Was it here to forage?

When my hand didn't disappear and instead passed through the air as one would expect in a world where strange temporal passageways don't exist, I straightened and shakily strode to the sink to pour myself some water. It sloshed over the wavy brown rim as I held the mug, but I forcibly lifted it to my mouth, at which point an involuntary jerk of my wrist sent it sailing floorward to clatter into two separate pieces. I sighed, and picked up the remains before walking more slowly this time to the bin and pushing the foot-pedal.

The creature screeched and tore past me, bringing the contents of the trash along with it. In its mouth, it clutched a brown paper bag, and I inwardly cursed. Of course my one cheat meal a week from my mostly-vegan diet would be what attracted this strange creature. In the wild, you know not to bring any meat or fish that could attract predators. Now that this thing seemed to treat my kitchen as part of its territory, the same rule applied.

Watching its form slip past me from within the small bin, I had to marvel at its being able to fit inside; it was when I saw its head disappear into nothingness once more that I realised that it had never been entirely inside after all. And now it had littered my kitchen floor with day-old food remains! Against my better judgement and all of my training in animal management, I lunged forward and grabbed the reptile's tail, determined to follow it through its latest portal.

The creature immediately whipped its tail to flick me off, but I held fast. We passed through the gap into another kitchen, still my own but in the daytime and with a new mug upside down on the draining board. It had "COFFEE" written on it in a tall, skinny font a la Rae Dunn. Future me had some basic taste.

We continued to another version of my kitchen, and the thing snaked back towards

me, snapping its monstrous teeth. I croaked rather than screamed, but before its jaws could clamp down on my skull, its tail whipped me away to its back, overpowering my grip and sending me flying into the cupboards once more.

“You really are stupid,” I – another me – commented from where I sat at the small table, holding a large, misshapen hot pink mug that had to be some child’s art project, perhaps inspired by a dragonfruit. “Thanks to you, we’re going to spend a fortune in mugs. Still are. Am.”

I didn’t reply as I was still too winded to speak. In front of us, the reptile seemed not to realise that I was no longer attached to it and kept popping in and out of existence before us, making thundering rattles as it tried to shake off an imagined passenger for some time before it finally reappeared and lunged just in time to catch its own tail between its pointy teeth.

At the table, I took a sip and muttered, “Unstoppable object meets immovable force.” It sounded rehearsed.

Sitting in front of the creature, I finally got to my feet, though I couldn’t bring myself to approach it again. “What is it?” I asked, intensely aware of the pain of being thrown across the kitchen twice now. “And how can we get it out of the kitchen?”

“It’s a wyrm. And why should I tell you? I didn’t tell me,” was my irritated reply.

I frowned, inspecting the reptile. Eyes, feet, claws... “It’s not a worm.”

“A wyrm,” other me repeated. “Like a dragon.”

“Dragons aren’t real,” I blurted automatically, already regretting it as the hideous monstrosity of a mug was slammed angrily onto the tabletop. “Okay. It’s a dragon.”

“A wyrm,” I corrected myself, before turning away and pulling out my phone. “Anyway, figure it out yourself.”

Well, that was unhelpful. Turning my attention away from myself, I watched the wyrm, which seemed to notice my gaze as it finally released its scaly tail to glare up at me.

“What do you want?” I asked, but of course it didn’t reply.

Instead, it charged toward me, and I didn’t have the energy to dive away before it disappeared once again.

“Step forward,” my bored voice instructed. I obeyed.

Nothing happened. Then I was hit with a force from behind which knocked the breath from me, and found myself travelling through variations of the kitchen at various times of day, all with myself watching from a distance with varying degrees of surprise.

“Wha–” one asked, turning around from where I stood at the stove, dropping a floral pink mug before another me suddenly stood leaning against the counter, nodded at me and sipping from a speckled egg-blue teacup for a split-second until a third me waved from where I stood by the refrigerator with a pile of grey ceramic shards already at my feet. After several more visions of myself holding or dropping a variety of drinking vessels, I hit the floor, and the same self sat at the table once more, still scrolling and sipping from the same ugly mug. The wyrm now clambered over me, still skittering forward and leaving cuts and scratches on my skin and clothes as it passed over me.

“That hurt,” I mumbled on the floor.

At this point, I was aching, miserable, and worst of all – tired. Even if the sun shone through the windows now, it had been the middle of the night when I had first confronted the wyrm. No intellectual curiosity could compel me at this point to understand the creature properly. All I wanted was to crawl up the stairs and into bed, and take a nice hot bath after approximately 300 years of snoozing.

“It hurt,” other me agreed. “But did you work out why it’s like this?”

“Define like this,” I muttered, closing my eyes slowly. Just for a little...

“It’s anchored to this location, and it’s extremely aggressive,” my voice explained. I made a noise of acknowledgement. “Wake up! Work out why it’s being like this!”

With effort, I pried my eyelids apart and sat up.

“It’s anchored to here? Is it hiding its offspring here?” But it didn’t seem like a very parental creature. Even if it had eggs, where would it find space to nest in somewhere as small as a houseshare kitchen?

“Or this place is just part of its territory?” No, that didn’t seem right. It had only nested here recently. Or maybe it had nested here a long time ago, just in the future. It would explain my general lack of surprise at the situation.

“Or is it unwell?” That could be it. Why else would it remain somewhere as cloistered as my kitchen? It would prefer to remain in a small, cramped space to avoid any potential conspecifics or predators who would see it as an easy target. Predators... I shuddered at the thought of any beast large enough to see that monster as prey.

But if it were ill, how could I convince it to leave? Nurse it back to health? Forget spending money on mugs, I would have to spend all of my savings on meat if I were to. Given that the kitchen didn’t seem full of carcasses and wyrm faeces, I doubted that the solution involved an extended period of nurture.

“Injured?” I asked hesitantly, but I didn’t reply, once again absorbed in my phone. That damn phone!

Watching myself slurp yet more coffee did make me wonder, though. How did I get through so many mugs? Surely I wouldn’t have resorted to that ceramic atrocity unless forced to by circumstances. How many mugs was I doomed to break while plagued by the wyrm? Wouldn’t the shards be a health risk? Shards!

I scrambled to my feet, and gasped as something sharp dug into my knee. Inspecting the fabric, I found my confirmation – a ceramic shard was buried in the fabric of my jeans, and it took some intense pinching to pull it out. Scanning the floor, I couldn’t find any other scattered shards, but instead faint, gleaming gold prints. Crouching down to inspect one, a wild guess solidified to certainty.

“How can I trap it again?” I queried, and the familiar, now very chewed mattress cover was tossed to me.

It would do. It wasn’t optimal, but I didn’t have any better options approaching. I stood

back against the cabinets, wincing as the handles bumped against my sore ribs, and waited. When the wyrm reappeared this time, it finally stopped, and stood in place before me as it panted to repay its oxygen debt from the past few minutes of temporal cavorting. Resisting the desire to clamber onto the countertop and hide, I threw the fabric over the wyrm's face. The exhausted creature didn't respond, only lazily shaking its head before submitting after failing to dislodge the blind.

Slowly, cautiously, I crept around it and made what I hoped wouldn't be the most deadly mistake of my life. Given the creature's long bent legs and location on dry land in a kitchen less than a full two metres wide, I trusted that it wouldn't try – or succeed – in rolling me off. I perched on its back, preparing to be thrown into the next month, but fatigue and darkness seemed to make the wyrm docile. Grabbing one foot, I pulled it up off the floor to inspect the sole for any debris. Just like hoof-picking a donkey. Nothing was lodged in there, and the foot was free of any blood. The next two feet were the same, and the wyrm began to rumble its dissatisfaction as I finally lifted its fourth foot.

Crocodylians commonly known to exist on earth bleed, but very little. Vasoconstriction allows redirection of blood flow, and rapid blood clotting prevents any significant blood loss from the site of injury. The wyrm seemed the same, as the small ceramic splinter embedded in its food was surrounded by thin scabbing already, and even after I carefully removed it, no more than three thin, golden droplets of ichor-like serum dripped from within the wound before it began to form a translucent filmy scab where the intruding fragment had been.

The wyrm let out a loud rattle, and I shot to my feet, bolting to the door. To my relief, it didn't attempt any death rolls or anything of the sort, and only shook the mattress cover off its head before turning to me: the me at the door, staring down at the strange beast from where I had first observed it, wondering what strange creature was crashing about in my kitchen in the middle of the night. It turned and approached me, slowly, and my fingers gripped the door handle as its eyes seemed to lock onto mine. Gratitude? Anthropomorphism of animals was something that I usually avoided, but something in me hoped so. The wyrm stepped forward, made a small trilling noise, and then disappeared into a nothingness before me.

“Well done,” I said from the table, as I sank to the floor in clammy relief.

My legs were jelly, my arms were jelly, my torso ached, and my head almost rang with exhaustion.

“What do I do now?” I asked, or someone else seemed to with my mouth while my consciousness felt somewhere in the air above myself.

“You go home,” I replied. “Go to the countertop, and I’ll help you through the wormhole it left for you.”

Muscles screaming, I obeyed, and stood uncertainly at the spot where I had arrived into this time.

“This will work?” I asked, inexplicably distrusting of myself standing behind me with a malicious smile.

“Of course. I’ve been looking forward to this for months,” I heard myself mutter, shoving myself forward onto the cold tiles of a blissfully empty kitchen.

It was over. My body ached. Rising to my feet, I finally made my way to the door to retreat to my bedroom and take a very long nap. As I took hold of the handle, there was a skittering noise, and I turned in time to see the worm vanish in its familiar panic. My future self’s source of irritation was finally clear: the next few months were going to be very long. **ΨΦ**

The Worm Will Wait

by Julien C H Cheung

"Docking complete. What luck that there's gravity here, even if it's weak! To the airlock it is, our intrepid explorers!" The man behind the console turns around, smiling wryly as he waves us goodbye through the airlock's window. Some hissing later, the microphones in our shipsuits crackle with life. "Ramp extended. Outer airlock opening. Safe travels to you, brave pioneers!" The wiry man offers one final mock salute before the airlock mist returns, shrouding him behind the small viewport.

"Heh, thanks a bunch, Zeb." Zeb takes his role as the Mission Control technical expert "very seriously", as he'd like to say. He's always been a bit of a prankster, but the rest of us know we can rely on him. The person replying to him is Brad, this expedition's self-proclaimed "leader", our surveyor, and by-far the most experienced in alien expeditions out of us four. He carries himself with a haughty confidence striding down the ship's ramp, chin up as he skips down the ramp. Alie, the xenobiologist, looks at me, offers a shrug, then starts down herself, leaving me atop the ramp by myself. The licks of a cold sweat form on my back, and I can't help but watch the two seasoned veterans saunter downwards yet feel nothing but fear. Behind me, the ship's spotlight switches on, casting my gargantuan shadow over the back wall of the room. It is time for me to make it down the ramp.

My footsteps scatter what remains of the ramp's dust into the fleeting atmosphere. The place is so big that even the massive spotlight only barely illuminates the back wall of the bay, a cone of light marking the path forward. Our shadows, fuzzy at their edges, shrink as we slowly head down the ramp, warping as the spotlight tries desperately to keep the void at bay. Only the engineered white noise of our in-suit speakers puncture the deafening silence of the cavernous room. Butterflies begin to form in my stomach, but I try my best to force them down. Some part are because of that all-subsuming silence, a rarity back in my office at the Department of Xenoanthropology, but the remainder consists of nothing but anticipation. Those same butterflies now tie knots in my gut as the giddiness of new discovery races through me. We're the first of our kind to step foot on an alien ship, and as those comments behind my back in the Institute

would suggest, what's not to envy about that?

"One small step for us-" Brad puffs out his chest before taking the final step, "-and it won't be the last. Hey, Alie, wait-" A smack to the back of his helmet is followed by a litany of complaints from Brad, and I watch as Alie laughs to his misfortune. "Aw, man!"

"Don't forget to include Grace. She's always complaining that we leave her out." I almost jump. It's easy to forget that Zeb has a direct link to the shipsuit cameras, and both Alie and Brad turn to laugh at me.

"Really? We're back to these cheap tactics again?" I put on the best disappointed face I can muster. Alie can't help but let out a chuckle, so I roll my eyes at her.

"That's a yes from her, then." The microphone crackles to life with its own laughter, and I can almost see the Zeb shrug beside me. My eyebrows furrow on instinct, and Brad along with Alie look at me wryly. I shrug, a smirk beginning to form. With a signal from Brad, we choose to start towards the back wall, remaining in the cone of the ship's spotlight. We travel what I've deemed the 'Steel Wastes' for the first leg of our journey, two minutes of the pitter-patter of boots on some cold, metallic alloy. Halfway through our journey, the featureless grey wall reveals three notches, wide-open blast doors that guard their secrets using the void itself. Above these doors is a small logo, the first piece of artwork we've seen from an extraterrestrial civilisation, and my heart skips a beat. Quickly signalling to Brad, fine camerawork provides me with the brain food I've been craving. Though there's holes in the paint from eons of exposure to the cosmos, enough of it is still intact that I can make out surface details. An orange circle enclosing three smaller green circles, arranged in no particular configuration. A surprisingly-intact purple stripe runs down its centre, cleaving the banner almost perfectly in half. There's some odd appendages that seem to stretch from the stripe, though they've been worn down so thoroughly I can barely tell what they resemble.

"Zeb, what do you make of this?"

"Looks like a centipede... hmmm. No legs. A worm would fit better. Say, doesn't this sound like The Wyrms of the Ancient Derelict? That tale ol' Martin wuz' ramblin'

'bout?" He adds a mock trawl to his voice. My chuckle makes both Brad and Alie turn.

I give up suppressing my smile. "You don't seriously believe in that, do you?"

"As if the ever-MAGNANIMOUS Zeb would ever!"

"Jesus, stop it!" That smile turns into a grin. "That's not even how you use that word!"

"No? Wait, what?" Confusion creases the edges of his voice. Alie can't stifle her own laughter anymore, and she splutters into her microphone. "Hey! We aren't all linguistically-inclined!"

"Alright, alright, enough wormin' around, y'all." He laughs heartily at his own joke. "Now, onto business."

Brad's grin dims to a smile, and he gestures to one of the three open doors into the bowels of the ship. "We've three doors for the three of us. We'll use our radars to scan – it's connection-independent, so follow protocol if there's no signal – let's meet up, say, an hour into this, if we don't have any signal?"

The halo of the spotlight slowly fades behind me as my flashlight sweeps through the darkness, and soon it is only the clatter of my boots on hard steel that guides me deeper into the abyss. Whatever material the ship's made of absorbs every piece of light, almost as if it is the void itself, and I have to switch off my night vision to remove the stars in my eyes. I swear that every so often, as the click, clack of my suits' many carabiners echoes within itself, there's the sound of a leaky pipe and the slow pooling of water somewhere, but each sweep of the nearby floor yields nothing of the sort. Each tunnel is almost perfectly cylindrical save for a large gash to one side, where a large wire runs parallel to the ground.

"Comms. Testing. Testing. Anyone here?" I yell, and I swear the walls undulate to respond. The network of corridors deep in the ship's core twists and turns until I can't tell my north from south, flanked in almost every direction by plain-grey blast doors. Intersections come and go as they please, turning my weaving, dodging tunnel into a three-dimensional mess of gargantuan proportions. Soon, it is impossible to tell which way I've gone, and panic begins to grip me. The radar tool glows a brilliant, sickly green as I watch two small dots carve paths of knowledge through more tunnels. I

decide to try finding Alie, her icon glowing far brighter than Brad. Following her trail of breadcrumbs, it is not long until I find my first anomaly. A doorway beckons me closer, a screen with a large crack flickering slowly to its left. An orange cylinder, almost as tall as I am, floats motionlessly in the air close by, complete with impact dents on its side.

Walking into the room, it is immediately obvious that I've stumbled across the mess hall. Just left of the room's entrance is the empty plastic shelves of a canteen counter, complete with a box and a poor imitation of the dollar sign painted on it. To complete the hall is a mass of gaudy, neon-green benches and tables, still drifting and bumping into each other. I barely dodge a neon-green plastic stool hurtling at me, its sides chipped from all the impacts.

Some static is the only warning I receive when I suddenly hear Zeb's panicked voice. "Whoah, whoah, below you, watch OUT!" I jump so high that I hit the ceiling, and I massage my head gingerly as I slowly float down onto a small alcove where the furniture stays still.

"Zeb, I-"

"Look down." I do as he asks, and only then do I see the large chasm beneath me leading directly to outer space. Though there's almost no air, the temperature still seems to sink 20 degrees. I can only stare into the abyss, where a nebula peers back curiously, as I catch my breath on one of the benches. If I'd tripped, been sent out of the ship-

"Grace. I don't know what happened. This room's exposure to-" he cuts out for a moment, "god- this room's exposure to o-outer space is enough for me to get some connection, including for all your shipsuit passive instruments. Something's off, Grace."

"What do you-

"I tried looking at what could've blocked all our signals. No EMP – we know that, we'd have found it. The hull's just some modified tungsten-nickel, nothing jamming. He stops for a moment, and when his voice returns, there's a sheepish ring to it. "I, uhh... may know of certain spy ships which paint their hulls with conductive paints. Jams signals. There isn't a lick of the stuff we use, or hell, anything that could give those

properties on this metal. Stay with me, Grace. You're the only one I've managed to connect to in all this time."

"Mhm, right." I gingerly massage my head. My vision is a tad bit blurry, but I squeeze my thoughts through my mouth. "But isn't it wrong to extrapolate to this ship? We don't know anything these aliens, they could've-

"Yes, yes, alright, I do know that, but my assumptions are based on what we've seen on this ship so far. With something this large, with a dedicated docking bay like thi-is, there's no way this doesn't have some sort of strike-craft capability. We're talking about a large fleet ship by human standards, Grace." "Just think, please," he says before I'm about to. "At the very least, these aliens would've been rational, no?" I don't respond.

"A-and don't get me started on just WHAT could've created that gash! It's like those corridors you were moving through – how's it so smooth? We'd expect ballistics to leave some sort of mark here and there, but the joins of the metal, they've popped out so perfectly! The cleanliness suggests mass driver, but even that leaves fragments here and there, and don't get me started on how energy this one would need. Why would anyone, anything bother to make a weapon like this? It just doesn't make sense!" I can't answer him, and I turn away from the gash, placing my head on my hand as I scour it for an explanation.

"I- I don't know." I curse, having wracked my brain for something useable, only to return dizzier than before. "You'd hate this Zeb, but the only thing I can think of is some sort of... ceremony. With a large weapon-." Suddenly, there's what sounds like a loud screech that echoes through the room, and I hit my head for the second time today. That elicits a low groan out of me, but the adrenaline helps me to my feet.

"Hey, Grace, wait-" Zeb cuts out as I continue putting distance between the gash, and I turn tail, rushing down the corridor as fast as I can. It is only at the next intersection when I realise I've taken the wrong turn, but the adrenaline wears out, and I slump to the floor. Looking at the radar, Brad and Alie have pushed further into the ship, and I realise that they intend to meet me at wherever our tunnels converge.

"Brad, Alie?" My footsteps seem to crunch on sand as I trudge slowly forwards. The

sound of crashing metal seems stuck in my ears, a constant ringing that combines with a low hum barely perceptible. Sometimes, the sound of chatter just up ahead is enough to send me bursting ahead, clawing at the darkness as if I can disperse it myself, only to find nothing but a solitary dust mote, drifting under the watchful eye of my flashlight. Another intersection lies up ahead, and a raspy, pained screech in the distance sends me scattering haplessly to the left this time. I want so desperately to cling to the wall, to dispel the dizziness, the tears welling up in my eyes. Yet, I know I cannot, so I grasp my trembling flashlight tighter and press forward.

Small flickers of blues and purples puncture the , almost like fireflies in the brush, yet they're always just out of reach, eluding my outstretched arms no matter how much they stretch. The pitter-patter of water turns into a raging torrent that floods my ears. The corridors sweep closer together, constricting with each new bend. There's just more of that same alien metal, every sixty or seventy metres away from the last bend.

I do not know how long it takes until I find another set of open blast doors, but I can't help but sprint towards the set that lie at the end of the corridor. Soft oranges, reds, and purples are each locked in an endless dance to the death, filter weakly through the door, a far mimicry of moonlight. The room itself is a small semicircular atrium, where eight command chairs surround one central chair. Two more blast doors, each one left swinging, form to the left and right of me. The two are nowhere to be found, until Alie comes hurtling through the room, coming to a stop as she slams into one of the many consoles around the room. Brad makes his entrance behind me, his gait slow and steady. I rush to her side, helping

"Grace! Brad!" She yells, as she comes to a stop on all fours. Wiping the sweat off the brow, there's a distinct wild look to her eyes now. "It's not safe. I- I swear, man, there was this weird room- there was-

"Whoah, woah, calm down. You're safe with us. What happened?"

"Thank you, Brad." She pats herself down, before a steady stream of tears begins to run into her shipsuit. "There was this- this weird gash in this corridor, leading out to space, and when I looked through them, I swear, there was this horrible set of glowing

purple eyes! I got out of there as fast as I could, but I- there's a voice in my mind. I'm sure of it! I'm not-"

"That's enough, Alie. We'll take it from here, right, Grace?" He shoots a quintessentially Brad grin at me. His mouth seems a little wider than usual.

"I was lost in there, Brad! And- and you two just abandoned me, didn't you?"

"What could we have done? We were both ... lost, huh, Grace?" Brad turns to look at me, laughing as he does so. "That is, until the Worm found us. It gave me its light, showed me the path forward."

"Brad, I'm not sure where you're going with this." I cough out, slowly backing away. Brad holds my gaze, moving forward with impossible precision. The nebula catches Brad's eye for a split second, and they glisten a brilliant magenta. Suddenly, he turns to Alie, lunging at her.

"W-what are you doing? What's that-" There's a sound as if she has the wind knocked out of her, then a gurgle, and she doubles over clutching her stomach, a trickle of blood streaming upwards into her helmet. She stares at Brad with sad eyes, before collapsing on the floor.

"Shhh... the Worm welcomes you. Rest easy..." He traces the rim of her spacesuit's helmet, making clawing motions at her ponytail, before he turns to me, straightening his back. "The Worm beckons, Grace. We'll be together, forever, with the worm, won't we..."

"You're insane." I make a leap behind a console. Brad continues his slow, circling motion around the horseshoe. I reach into my utility belt, and produce my own utility knife, brandishing it in front of my face. "Stay back!"

"Oh, Grace. He's murdered one of your compatriots. He's ... a traitor, to the cause." A voice, as gravelly as it is deep, seeps from the walls, the consoles, and my own shadow. The light from the nebula glows brighter. Brad turns away as if blinded by something.

"No, no! I haven't- no-" Brad begins, but something seems to stifle his voice. He's left

part-suspended a metre in the air, and he makes these awful sounds, dropping the knife to grasp at his throat.

“Grace. He failed where you shall not. A failed peon of mine has no place in this universe.” The knife trembles in my hand. The voice continues, this time with the soft trawl of home. “It’s time, Grace. Do what you must.”

I wipe the blood from my helmet. From the corner of my eye, I see a band of dust coalesce around itself, forming into claws, scales, until it resembles a human dragon. It closes both its’ ‘eyes’, two bright purple dots flickering out of existence for a moment, before dissipating again. That same static in my speaker starts up again, and I answer it with a smile.

“Grace? Oh god, Grace, thank god. Get back to base camp immediately. We’re getting the hell out. And- oh, Jesus, what the devil happened here?”

“The ... Worm spoke through me, Zeb. Not one of your gods.”

“I- what?”

“Zeb, it welcomes us. It has waited for millennia. It can wait millennia more, just for you.” ΨΦ

Through the Center of the Earth

by Michael Porat-Bachmutsky

A great hunger wells within Earth's malebolge,
Pulsing, shifting his surrounding hellstone,
Invading crevices within ashen dust,
Exhaling meteoric waves of burning gas
. Pressure builds and builds -
Until eruption,
Over centuries, untampered and unbidden,
Mutating lifeless limbs into gluttonous claws
Carving even the void in his path,
Immolating weeping souls
Trapped flesh-in-ore,
Plucking their agony
From hardened rock,
Feeding on it,
Destroying it.

Yet through all his gluttony,
He remains insatiable. **ΨΦ**

Jörmungandr

by Alyssa Renata

It began with the elongation: the thrashing onto land
Head and tail diverge, the breaking of the band
The puncturing of reality, awaken O gourmand!

“Worry not,” they say — “escape is possible!”
But in their hearts they know, for they have glimpsed the inevitable
Each immanent wave a great revelation of the wreath
We march to our graves, partaking in one last death

It is the end of ages, all torn asunder
Your appetite knows no end, and we can but flounder
in darkness, in shadow of the great oppressor... ΨΦ

